

Environmental Impact of Generative AI

Posted by u/EchoOfOppenheimer • 0 points • 18 comments

We often think of "the cloud" as invisible, but a new report reveals the staggering physical footprint of Generative AI. Did you know that generating a single AI image uses as much energy as **half a smartphone charge**? Or that the AI boom in 2025 released roughly as much CO2 as **New York City** does in a year?

Comments

u/Caderent • 0 points • 2026-02-13 07:54 UTC The correct title should be, generation single image with dimensions 10x of universe takes as much as all the power in universe. As much as are the key words. Generating an average image takes way less power.
u/DistributionRight261 • 1 points • 2026-02-12 17:05 UTC Once GPU are replaced by TPU, the issue will be way smaller.
u/Ignislason • -2 points • 2026-02-12 10:33 UTC AI power consumption is about 1/3 the size of bitcoin's.
u/Sonario648 • 1 points • 2026-02-17 00:24 UTC Shitcoin is still alive?
u/Neat_Tangelo5339 • 5 points • 2026-02-12 19:45 UTC We should get rid of that too
u/jferments • -4 points • 2026-02-12 10:27 UTC You could offset an entire year of AI use by eating one less cheeseburger per year. If you use AI regularly throughout the day, it will use less energy than running a small light bulb for a couple of hours. Streaming video and online gaming use far more energy than AI. This entire article is filled with misinformation and out of context, deliberately misleading statistics. The entire issue of the "staggering" environmental footprint of AI is massively overblown. You want to attack energy hungry data centers? You should be looking at Netflix, not AI.
u/standread • 8 points • 2026-02-12 11:30 UTC It's ironic you're quoting the cheeseburger thing. That study is not peer reviewed, estimates variables like power consumption through satellite imagery and makes other unfounded assumptions to reach its point. u/jferments • -4 points • 2026-02-12 11:38 UTC I'm not sure which study you're referring to, but anyone is welcome to go look up how much energy/water is used to produce beef (~6.5 kwh of energy and 15000 liters of water per lb just for production - not including transport and refrigeration) and compare that to how much is used to process a GPT prompt (~0.005kwh and 1-4ml / prompt). u/Awkward-Contact6102 • 2 points • 2026-02-12 14:23 UTC That also depends on what you are generating audio,video or text and the size of the prompt and the rest of the context window. Most of these numbers are just estimates. Fact is it uses a lot of energy. Why else would a company like meta launch their own nuclear energy projects? u/CaptStinkyFeet • 1 points • 2026-02-12 13:19 UTC Gotta love the "google it yourself" folks. You made the claim, you back it up with a source. No one is doing your homework for you. u/Ok-Lobster-919 • 1 points • 2026-02-12 23:52 UTC Why is Everyone So Wrong About AI Water Use?? https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H\c6MWk7PQc u/jferments • -1 points • 2026-02-12 23:52 UTC I love how you literally asked me to do your homework for you, and then claimed that it was me asking. I gave easily verifiable figures to back up my argument and the person that responded to me gave no sources or figures and just said it wasn't true. Unsurprisingly, you didn't ask for sources from them. Fortunately, I've had these discussions hundreds of times and have plenty of sources on

hand for people like you that want me to do their homework for them. Here's a few to get started with, which talk both about energy/water use in the meat industry and for AI. Let me know if you need me to do more of your homework for you after you read them (surely you're actually going to read the sources you requested, right?)

[1] Environmental footprints of beef cattle production in the United States:
[https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0308521X18305675]
(https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0308521X18305675)

[2] The On-Site Energy Demand of Meats Consumed in Restaurants:
[https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0921344920301658]
(https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0921344920301658)

[3] How Hungry is AI? Benchmarking Energy, Water, and Carbon Footprint of LLM Inference: https://arxiv.org/html/2505.09598v2

[4] The hidden water resource use behind meat and dairy:
[https://academic.oup.com/af/article/2/2/3/4638610]
(https://academic.oup.com/af/article/2/2/3/4638610)

[5] Cradle-to-farm gate environmental footprints of beef cattle production in Kansas, Oklahoma, and Texas: [https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/26020346/]
(https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/26020346/)

[6] In a first, Google has released data on how much energy an AI prompt uses
(https://www.technologyreview.com/2025/08/21/1122288/google-gemini-ai-energy/)

u/duckduckduckgoose8 • 2 points • 2026-02-13 03:20 UTC

Doing gods work chief 🙌👑

u/lmthewienerdog • -1 points • 2026-02-12 17:09 UTC

They literally gave you the math?

u/CaptStinkyFeet • 1 points • 2026-02-12 21:22 UTC

No, they pulled figures out of nowhere and said "google it if you don't believe me".

Did you know horses queef 5x as much as cows? You'd think it would be cows, considering the internal area of their *you know what* is approximately 1.4x larger, but on average horses queef at 3.3x the frequency of cows, so when you calculate the total volume of air, horses take the win.

If you don't believe me, just google it!

u/lmthewienerdog • -2 points • 2026-02-12 21:40 UTC

right so if i wanted to have a conversation with you about how much animals queef? i would use those numbers and look online if they are similar to other result, after we could have a discussion about it. you already backed up your claim with these numbers so there is no reason for me to ask for them again?

u/CaptStinkyFeet
• 1 points •
2026-02-12
22:13 UTC

I didn't back up any claims because that's not what backing up a claim is. You need a source. Thats like day one of high school, you can't just pull out statistics from nowhere

and
assume
that's
sufficient.
Who put
those stats
out? How
did they
collect their
data? etc.
You make a
claim, you
back it up
with a
source.
And no, we
won't
Google it.
We're not
going to do
your
homework
for you.

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